the territory of modern Netherlands had nearly doubled their income since 1500 to 1,381 dollars, the highest in Europe, while that of the modern-day UK was 974. What today are Greece and Finland remained below the Eastern Europe average, but Spain and Portugal took off, largely because of the discoveries in the New World. A hundred years later, in 1700, the Eastern European average GDP per capita is estimated at 606 dollars. That of the UK was then almost double that figure (1,250) and the Netherlands had got an even firmer lead with 2,130 dollars. Greece and Finland, each at its own fringe of Europe, were again lagging behind or were just about catching up with the Eastern European average.[20]

To summarise this episode of Eastern European history, over the centuries, things turned upside down in the region. In the early Middle Ages, Greek Byzantium stood a good chance of becoming the master even in Central Europe. Greek missionaries, most notably Constantine and Methodius, operated among the early Czechs, Slovaks and Slovenians but were ultimately evicted and replaced by German and (for a short period) more amicable Irish missionaries. Thus these lands were already lost to Byzantium and Orthodox Christianity at a very early stage of history. The schism in the Church created the gap between Central and Eastern Europe. The gap between Central Europe and the Balkans, however, was created and then cemented by the Ottoman conquest. Greece, once the pivot of Europe and later of Eastern Europe and Orthodox Christianity, lost its primacy of the East and even of Orthodox Christianity. Such was the extent of this loss that today we are not accustomed to think of Greece as an Eastern European (and Balkan) country at all. In another twist of history, after its accession to the EU, Greece began to feature in the popular mind as a Western European country. In a way, the job of those medieval barbarians from the West had been completed.

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16. An excellent account of this transformation of the Catholic Church in an English setting is contained in the hilarious *How Far Can You Go?* by David Lodge, Penguin Books 1981.

17. Paradoxically, Pope Benedict XVI who had some sympathy for this Latin mass revival at the same time very much emphasised rationality in the Catholic faith, as expressed in his address at Regensburg in September 2006, which sparked so much indignation amongst Muslims. On the other side, Pope Francis issued instructions that severely limit the possibilities for celebrating the Latin mass, which he saw as an outer manifestation of the conservative strand in the Catholic Church, opposing the reforms of the Second Vatican Council.

18. See for example Bertrand Russell: ‘In the Eastern Church, the patriarch of Constantinople never